



DIAPHRAGMA

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PLAYERS RULEBOOK

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WHAT IS DIAPHRAGMA?



Welcome to **Diaphragma**, a modular narrative RPG built for fast, cinematic play, expressive storytelling and designed to be expanded through setting Frameworks. You'll read the room, find the angle, use your surroundings, exploit the weakness, and strike when everything lines up. When the dice hit the table, you've already done the work. Let's tell great stories!

"The guard patrols the same arc. Every thirty seconds, the doorway is empty.

You've counted four passes. The lantern inside throws his shadow before he reaches the window — that's your warning. The mud will muffle your steps. The broken shutter gives you two handholds.

You don't move until the moment is right. When you do, it counts."

Each story runs on a **Framework**, a setting layer your Storyteller picks that gives you the world, the threats, and the tone. The rules handle the rest.

WHAT YOU NEED

DICE One d10.

SHEETS Character sheets PDF

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

I've run a lot of different games. I love a tactical fight, positioning, setup, finding the angle that wins the moment. I also love the sessions where a player stops describing what they do and starts describing who they are while they do it.

For a long time, those two things felt like they were working against each other. Tactical games rewarded careful mechanical play, but the narration got thin. Narrative games let the story breathe, but felt that I am missing some of that crunch that made a tactical play so rewarding. You can play narratively in a tactical game, but the system doesn't help you. That weight falls entirely on the players, and I felt like my tables can't sustain it during sessions.

What I wanted was a play style where doing the smart thing and telling a good story were both rewarded by the table. Sometimes you do the smart thing, sometimes you do the cool thing. Sometimes you do the crazy thing. Sometimes you do the stupid thing. But all of it is part of the story, and all of it is part of the table.

I also run a lot of one shots. Different settings every few weeks: a heist, a horror crawl, a war story. Every time I had to teach a new system or bend the tone to fit rules that weren't built for the genre. I wanted one engine I could trust across all of it, and change the world by swapping the Framework, not the rulebook.

Diaphragma is that engine.

This is my attempt to find that thin line between crunch and narrative freedom.

FOUR DESIGN COMMITMENTS

CINEMATIC

One roll covers a complex action. You describe the whole move and roll once.

RESOURCEFUL

Bonuses come from what is in the scene. The high ground you took, the darkness you moved through, the gear in your hand. Smart play earns real mechanical advantage.

EXPRESSIVE

Your character is built from lived experience. I trained as a soldier. I read law at university. That history is what you roll with. I want to enable the player to play the fantasy character they want to play

MODULAR

The core rules ship without a setting. They are designed to pair with a Framework, a layer your Storyteller builds that adds the world, the tone, and the genre. Same engine, different game.

"A game is a series of interesting choices."

SID MEIER

CORE CONCEPTS

THE DIE

Diaphragma uses one die: a **d10**. Before you roll, choose to **Settle** for a fixed 5, or **Roll** and take what the die gives you. The result is then modified by Edges (+1 each) and Bains (-1 each).

Final result: 2-6 Failure, 7-9 Partial Success, 10+ Success.

A natural **1** is always a Critical Failure. A natural **10** is a Critical Success.



SETTLE OR ROLL

Before rolling, choose: **Settle** treats your result as 5, **Roll** means you pick up the d10 and take whatever comes.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

A final result of 7-9. You progress the story, but the Storyteller adds a cost, complication, or new pressure.

BURDENS

A flaw. When a Burden is relevant, the best possible result is **Partial Success**. Full Success is off the table regardless of Edges.

STORYTELLER TOKENS

The Storyteller's resource for pushing back. Spend **1ST** to invoke a Bain against a player action. The Storyteller starts each scene with a set number. Burdens never cost ST.

PLAYS

Special abilities tied to a Framework. Things your character can do that the core rules do not cover: powers, maneuvers, and techniques defined by the setting.

EDGES & BAINS

Edges are favorable factors worth **+1** each: gear, position, preparation, enemy weakness. Bains are unfavorable factors that subtract **-1** each.

NARRATIVE POINTS

A pool shared by all players. Earned when critical moments happen. Spend **1NP** for cool effects or narrative boosts.

PROFICIENCIES & SPECIALTIES

Your character's background, written as lived experience. Determines what actions and gear you can invoke as Edges.

FRAMEWORKS

A rules layer added on top of the core system. Each Framework defines a setting: its tone, character options, powers, gear, enemies, and any special rules.

LEGENDARY PLAYS

Created from a specific moment in play. Spends a **Legendary Token**, to make it a permanent ability

CORE RULES

How the game works. Start here.

CORE RESOLUTION

Diaphragma uses one die: **a d10**.

Not every action needs a roll. If there is nothing pushing back the action simply succeeds. If failure is certain regardless of effort, it simply fails. You only roll when the outcome is genuinely uncertain, when something in the fiction is pushing back, when there is a real cost if things go wrong.

WHEN TO ROLL

Roll when there is active opposition, a real chance of failure, or a meaningful cost if things go wrong.

No roll needed when the character is clearly capable and nothing is pushing back. It just happens.

No roll possible when failure is already certain. The fiction decides, the die does not.

When a roll is called for, the player either **Settles** or **Rolls**.

SETTLE

Skip the roll. Your raw result is **5**. But you can never critically succeed or fail.

ROLL

Roll **1d10**. The number on the die is your raw result. Risk and reward both go up.

RESULT TIERS

After all Edges and Bains are applied:

RESULT	OUTCOME
Natural 1	Critical Failure
2 – 6	Failure
7 – 9	Partial Success
10+	Success
Natural 10	Critical Success

CRITICALS

Criticals only come from the **natural die result**.

NATURAL 1

Always a **Critical Failure**, no Edges can prevent it.

NATURAL 10

Critical Success, but only if no relevant Burden blocks success.

RESOLUTION PROCEDURE

1 Describe what you want and **how** you do it.

2 The Storyteller confirms the action is possible and declares any relevant **Burden**.

3 The table identifies **Edges** (+1 each) and **Bains** (-1 each).

Settle (result = 5) or **Roll** (1d10). Apply Edges and Bains. A Burden caps the result at 9.

5 The Storyteller calls the outcome and advances the fiction.

CRITICAL FAILURE

Only on a natural 1. Something goes badly wrong beyond the action itself. The player is encouraged to narrate what happens, own the failure and make it dramatic!

FAILURE

Result of 2–6. The fiction does not move in your favor. The Storyteller describes what holds.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

Result of 7–9. The fiction move in your favor, but at a cost. The Storyteller adds a complication, pressure, or price.

SUCCESS

Result of 10+. Clean outcome. You get exactly what you wanted with no cost or complication attached.

CRITICAL SUCCESS

Only on a natural 10. You get what you wanted and something extra. The player is encouraged to narrate the moment, own the success and describe how it lands and what it means.



PROFICIENCIES & SPECIALTIES

Characters are defined by what they have **learned, practiced, and lived through**.

PROFICIENCIES

Proficiencies are broad descriptions of what a character is good at, written as lived experience. A Proficiency does not grant a flat bonus. It is fictional license for arguing that an Edge is plausible at all.

I TRAINED AS A SOLDIER

I STUDIED MEDICINE IN WAR CAMPS

I HUNTED BEASTS IN THE MARSH FOR YEARS

I LEARNED TO READ PEOPLE AT COURT

A Proficiency does three things:

- **Gates invocations** — establishes what actions and gear are within your competence.
- **Justifies Edges** — lets you point to your background and say “this covers it.”
- **Anchors Specialties** — it is the container your Specialties hang off of.

INVOKING AT THE TABLE

Player: “I trained as a soldier — I’ve crossed checkpoints like this a hundred times. I know how to look like I belong. That’s my Edge for this roll.”

Player: “I hunted beasts in the marsh for years. I can read how this creature moves. I want to invoke that as an Edge — I know where it’s about to strike before it does.”

SPECIALTIES

Specialties are narrow, concrete focuses that hang off a Proficiency. When a Specialty clearly applies, it contributes **+2**.

PROFICIENCY	SPECIALTY
Trained as a soldier	Rifle marksmanship
Medicine in war camps	Battlefield surgery
Hunted beasts in the marsh	Tracking wetlands

Multiple Specialties can hang off the same Proficiency. This is the intended way to build a character. Pick a few broad Proficiencies, then stack specific Specialties under them.



EDGES, GEAR & INVOKING

WHAT IS AN EDGE?

An **Edge** is any favorable fictional factor that helps the character. Each Edge is worth **+1** when invoked. Edges may come from gear, allies, position, environment, preparation, information, or enemy weakness.

LOADED REVOLVER +1

HIGH GROUND +1

SILVER CHAIN ALREADY IN HAND +1

ALLY IS PINNING THEM +1

I EXAMINED THE WOUND EARLIER +1

I KNOW THESE WOODS +1

INVOKING

Invoking means calling out an Edge and using it for +1. You may invoke Edges before or after the roll, when Settling or Rolling. There is no limit to the number of Edges you can invoke, even if they grant automatic success.

GEAR

Gear often creates Edges — but not all gear is equal.

USEFUL BY DEFAULT

A lantern in darkness. A rope on a cliff. An explosive against a barricade. Anyone can invoke these.

REQUIRES TRAINING

Guns, complex weapons, technical tools, ritual equipment. Usually needs a relevant Proficiency to invoke effectively.

EDGE ECONOMY

Edges are not just bonuses, they are a measure of how well positioned a character is. A character with three active Edges has options: gear in hand, allies nearby, terrain in their favor. A character with none is exposed, unprepared, and running out of room.

The Storyteller's job is to apply narrative pressure that makes Edges harder to keep. The torch burns out. The ally goes down. You lose the high ground. As Edges disappear, the margin for failure narrows.

EDGES AS CREATIVE PLAY

There is no fixed list of valid Edges. If the fiction supports it and the table agrees, it counts. The player who looks at a scene and asks **"how can I use the darkness, the crowd, the broken pipe above them?"** is playing the game well. Creativity is mechanical advantage.

Edges also function as a health bar. When nothing applies and the roll comes, a Failure is not a minor setback, it is a real cost. Capture. A wound that does not heal. Death. As long as a player can keep Edges in play, the character has footing. Lose them all, and the situation is genuinely dangerous.

BURDENS & BAINS

These are the two main ways the fiction pushes back against the characters.

BURDENS

Burdens are defining flaws. They are not temporary setbacks, they define who the character is.

I FREEZE WHEN FIRE CLOSES IN

I STILL TRUST STEVE TOO MUCH

I CANNOT REFUSE A PUBLIC CHALLENGE

When a Burden applies it must be declared **before** the action is resolved. The action cannot achieve Success or Critical Success, the best possible outcome is **Partial Success**, even if Edges push the result to 10+.

GENERATING NP

If a Burden creates a dramatic moment that advances the story, it may generate **Narrative Points** for the group.

BURDENS VS BAINS

As a Burden: "Broken leg" is a defining lasting limitation. It follows the character everywhere, caps success on relevant actions, and cannot be easily removed.

As a Bain: "Broken leg" is a current condition worth -1 or -2. It can be healed, treated, or removed through play.

BAINS

Bains are active disadvantages that subtract from the final result. Usually temporary, bad positioning, enemy leverage, environmental hazards.

BROKEN LEG

-1

COVERED IN MUD

-1

BLINDED BY SPARKS

-2

MASTER SWORDSMAN'S GUARD

-2

PINNED BEHIND WEAK COVER

-1

Each Bain can normally be invoked **once** per action. The Storyteller invokes Bains at their discretion — when the fiction genuinely supports it, not to pile on.

SEVERITY	PENALTY
Normal	-1
Serious	-2
Extreme	-3

DECLARING BAINS

The Storyteller declares Bains before the player rolls, not after. It does not feel good to think you succeeded only to have a Bain appear and turn it into a failure. Players deserve to make informed choices about whether to Settle or Roll.

That said, players can walk into situations without fully grasping the danger, and sometimes a surprise is the right call if it makes the story genuinely better.

NARRATIVE POINTS

NARRATIVE POINTS (NP)

NP are a shared player currency. Any NP generated goes into one common pool for the whole group.

Each session begins with a number of NP equal to the **number of players**. This pool resets at the start of every new session.

NP may also be generated during play when:

- A player rolls a **Critical Failure** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A player rolls a **Critical Success** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A **Burden** is invoked in a way that creates strong narrative momentum

Spending NP each spend costs 1 NP:

SPEND	EFFECT
Reroll	Reroll a die you just rolled.
Injection	Add a useful fact or detail to the scene.
Flashback	Establish a brief prior preparation or memory.
Help	Give an ally a small immediate advantage.

THE FLOW OF PLAY

NP flows from dramatic moments. Critical rolls, and bold narration all put currency into the pool. The group decides together how to spend it.

Storyteller: "Ashford is watching you. He knows you're not who you said you were."

Mara's player: "NP spend — Injection. The Countess Vael is at this party. Mara knows her."

Storyteller: "She's by the clock tower stairs."

Mara's player: "I pull Ashford onto the floor and steer him straight toward her. Let him choose which problem matters more."

Storyteller: "His eyes move. You have until the waltz ends."



PLAYS & LEGENDARY PLAYS

PLAYS

Plays are setting-specific abilities, powers, maneuvers, or special actions defined by the Framework. They are the closest thing Diaphragma has to PbtA-style moves.

Plays do not grant a flat bonus by themselves. Instead, they:

- Create new fictional possibilities
- Establish new Edges that would not otherwise exist
- Bypass normal limitations
- Introduce costs, conditions, or tradeoffs

I CAN CONTROL FIRE

I CAN SHOOT IN A WHIRLWIND AND HIT EVERYONE NEARBY

I CAN VANISH INTO A CROWD ONCE PER SCENE

The exact wording, costs, and conditions of Plays are defined by the Framework your Storyteller is running.

LEGENDARY PLAYS

Legendary Plays are not chosen at character creation. They begin empty and are **created from play** — from the moments that become part of the character's legend.

When a player does something truly memorable, effective, or iconic, the Storyteller may offer them the chance to spend **1 Legendary Token** to lock that moment in as a permanent ability.

"The Vasquez Maneuver" — Dr.

Vasquez stabilized a dying colonist while being dragged through knee-deep water. Now, once per session, she can perform emergency treatment under conditions that would normally make it impossible.

"Hold the Corridor" — Sergeant Park

held a collapsing bulkhead alone while the team escaped. Now, once per session, when Park declares they will not move, nothing can move them.

LEGENDARY TOKENS

Each player starts with **2 Legendary Tokens** for the story or campaign. If a player does not spend the token immediately, they may define the Legendary Play later. Tokens may be refreshed at the Storyteller's discretion.

CHARACTERS

Building who you are.

CHARACTER CREATION

STATS AND CAPACITY

ANCHORS

GEAR

PROGRESSION

TRAITS

FLAWS

BURDENS

POWER LEVELS

GAMEPLAY LOOPS

Combat, scenes, and consequences.

PACING: SCENES VS DOWNTIME

CONFLICT

Conflict in Diaphragma covers any situation where opposing forces clash — a negotiation, a chase, a fight, a standoff, a desperate argument. The rules do not change based on the type of conflict. The fiction determines the stakes; the dice resolve the uncertainty.

HOW CONFLICT WORKS

A conflict is a scene with **active opposition**. Something is pushing back and the outcome is not certain. Both sides want something, and at least one side is willing to act to get it.

The Storyteller frames the situation — who is involved, what is at stake, and what success and failure look like for both sides. Then the scene plays out through a series of actions and rolls.

TYPES OF CONFLICT

All conflicts use the same resolution. The fiction changes; the rules do not.

COMBAT

NEGOTIATION / PERSUASION

CHASE / PURSUIT

STANDOFF / INTIMIDATION

SOCIAL MANEUVERING

SABOTAGE / RACE AGAINST TIME

ENDING A CONFLICT

A conflict ends when one side achieves their goal, can no longer act, or chooses to disengage. The Storyteller narrates the outcome based on where the fiction landed, not just the last roll.

THE 10-SECOND CUT

When multiple characters act at the same time — a firefight, a brawl, a chaotic negotiation — the Storyteller **cuts the scene into 10-second moments**.

Each 10-second window is one beat of action. Everyone at the table declares what their character does in that window. The Storyteller resolves each action in the order that makes the most fictional sense, then cuts to the next moment.

HOW A MOMENT PLAYS OUT

- 1 The Storyteller describes the current state of the scene.
- 2 Each player declares **what** their character does in the next 10 seconds.
- 3 The Storyteller calls any Bains. Players identify Edges.
- 4 Rolls are resolved. The fiction advances.
- 5 Cut to the next moment. Repeat until the conflict resolves.

SIMULTANEOUS ACTIONS

Actions within the same 10-second window are considered simultaneous. If two characters are shooting at each other, both rolls happen. A character who goes down in this window still completes their declared action — they land the hit before they drop.

CONSEQUENCES

CONDITION TRACKS

GM TOOLKIT

Running the game.

PRINCIPLES

NPCS AND THREATS

THE TOOLBOX

REFERENCE

Tables, definitions, and sheets.

QUICK REFERENCE TABLES

DEFINITIONS

CHARACTER SHEET